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PRAGGNANANDHAA IS CLEARLY THE ONE THAT NO CONTENDER CAN AFFORD TO TAKE LIGHTLY, HAVING FINISHED RUNNER-UP TO CARLSEN IN LAST YEAR'S WORLD CUP

five-time World champion Viswanathan Anand played in this premier event between 1991 and 2014.

This time, five out of 16 Candidates are Indians. R. Praggnanandhaa, D. Gukesh and Vidit Gujrathi are among the eight men while K. Humpy and R. Vaishali are part of the eight ladies battling it out. Clearly, this is the best advertisement for the growing presence of Indians among the elite of the sport.

The double-round robin format and the time-control [see next page] suit the stronger players in the fray. Since the oldest players in their respective sections — 37-year-old Humpy and 36-year-old Hikaru Nakamura — are young enough to

deal with the testing duration of the competition, their experience could come in handy.

Let us take a look at the prospects of the Indians, who are strong enough to upset the odds:

R. Praggnanandhaa: Firmly on the learning curve, his graph reflects an upward swing. Blessed with the right temperament and groomed for

bigger challenges on a chess board, this 18-year-old is the strongest of the three Indians figuring in the bottom half of the seedings.

Going entirely by seedings, not many would give the Indians a chance of topping the field. But these days, barring the presence of Magnus Carlsen, no top seed seems to carry a better chance of winning than his closest challengers. With the World No. 1 and five-time World champion choosing to stay away from the World championship cycle, there are no clear favourites, in the strictest sense of the term.

The current bunch of Indians who have gate-crashed into elite competitions and periodically beat stronger players hold the promise of playing way above their rating. Praggnanandhaa is clearly the one that no contender can afford to take lightly. After all, exceeding all expectations, he finished runner-up to Carlsen in last year's World Cup. It was this result that earned Praggnanandhaa a place among the Candidates.

Going by his opening repertoire, Praggnanandhaa appears well prepared with both colours. He is willing to play the waiting game and stays alert to seize his chance. In

situations where time is at a premium and quick calculations are needed, Praggnanandhaa can be trusted to stay cool and find the stronger of the available alternatives.

What makes him different from his compatriots is his ability to deal with disappointing results. Praggnanandhaa is quick to get over a missed win ending in a draw, or a rare loss from a seemingly drawn position. Mentally, he does not take long to get ready for the next game, without carrying any baggage of a disappointing result from the previous round.

From the days of the pandemic when cash-rich online Tour took roots in shorter duration formats, Praggnanandhaa slowly caught the attention of the chess world by getting some astounding victories, including a few over Carlsen. He stayed undefeated against several other elite players to underline his growing stature. After establishing himself as a serious contender among the elite in rapid and blitz, Praggnanandhaa turned his focus to the classical format. As a result, in the 24-month period between March 2022 to March 2024, his classical rating rose from 2619 to 2747 and established him firmly among the World's top-20.

Given his sustained training under illustrious coach R. B. Ramesh, Praggnanandhaa is expected to continue to add to his reputation. Toronto could see him pull off some stunning results.



Format (Open): Players compete in a double round-robin basis for a total of 14 rounds. The time control is 120 minutes for the first 40 moves, followed by 30 more minutes for the rest of the game. There's a 30-second increment starting on move 41.

No draw agreement before Black's 40th move.

Prizes: Total prize-fund is 500,000 euros — 48,000 euros for the winner, 36,000 euros for the runner-up, and 24,000 euros for the second runner-up. Additionally, players receive 3,500 euros for every half-point scored.